SOUTH INDIAN COLLECTION

NO. 08



KERALA ORIGIN

Vegetable Stew

Kerala-Style Coconut Milk Stew

The Gentle Companion to Appam

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Vegetable Stew

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Kerala's Coastal Trade History, in a Bowl

Kerala's vegetable stew reflects the state's centuries-long position as a hub of the international spice trade, where Arab, Chinese, and later European traders arrived seeking pepper, cardamom, and cinnamon, leaving culinary influence in their wake alongside the goods they carried away. The dish's gentle use of whole warming spices — cinnamon, cloves, cardamom — set in a rich coconut milk base rather than a chili-forward masala, reflects a style of cooking distinct from much of the rest of South India, often associated with Kerala's Syrian Christian community in particular.

Unlike most Indian curries built around ground spice blends, Kerala stew relies primarily on whole spices infused into the coconut milk, along with a generous hand of black pepper for warmth rather than red chili for heat — a choice that gives the dish a mellow, aromatic profile rather than an assertive one. Mixed vegetables — carrot, potato, beans, and often a small amount of protein like egg or chicken in non-vegetarian versions — simmer gently in this fragrant coconut broth until tender.

The dish holds particular significance during Christmas and Easter in Kerala's Christian communities, where it's a breakfast staple served alongside appam, though it has become widely loved and prepared across religious lines throughout the state, standing today as one of Kerala's most recognizable culinary exports.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Kerala's Coastal Trade History, in a Bowl, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Reflects Kerala's long history as an international spice trading hub, with culinary influences from Arab, Chinese, and European traders visible in its whole-spice technique. Especially associated with Kerala's Syrian Christian community, traditionally served during Christmas and Easter breakfast alongside appam. Distinguished by its reliance on whole spices and black pepper rather than ground chili powder for its flavor profile. Now enjoyed widely across religious and community lines throughout Kerala, beyond its specific festival associations.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	25m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Wide pot or pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Vegetable stew keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month, though coconut milk-based dishes can separate slightly on thawing — stir well while reheating gently over low heat.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the vegetables

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Carrot, diced	1 cup	120 g	1 katori
Potato, diced	1 cup	150 g	1 katori
Green beans, cut	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Green peas, fresh or frozen	½ cup	70 g	½ katori
Water, for boiling	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori

For the stew

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Coconut oil	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach
Cinnamon stick	1 inch	1 inch	1 inch
Cloves	4	4	4
Green cardamom	3	3	3
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Onion, sliced	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Ginger, julienned	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Green chili, slit	2	2	2
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the stew (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Thin coconut milk (second extract or diluted)	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Thick coconut milk (first extract)	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Black pepper, freshly ground	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Canned coconut milk works well as a substitute for fresh — use the thicker portion at the top of the can for "thick" coconut milk, and dilute the rest with a little water for the "thin" version. Coconut oil is important to the dish's authentic aroma, though a neutral oil can substitute if needed. This dish's vegetable combination is flexible, and cubed potato, carrot, and beans can be adjusted based on availability.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Base

01 BOIL THE VEGETABLES

Combine the carrot, potato, beans, and peas with water in a pot. Cook until just tender, about 10–12 minutes. Set aside, along with the cooking liquid.

02 BLOOM THE WHOLE SPICES

In a separate wide pot, heat coconut oil and add cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, and bay leaf, letting them sizzle gently for about 30 seconds until fragrant.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Base, continued

Chef tip. bloom the whole spices gently rather than at high heat — you want to release their aroma without scorching them.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The whole spices should smell distinctly fragrant and slightly toasted before you add the onion, signaling they've properly infused the oil.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Stew

03 SAUTÉ THE ONION AND AROMATICS

Add the sliced onion, ginger, green chili, and curry leaves, cooking until the onion turns soft and translucent, about 5–6 minutes.

04 ADD THIN COCONUT MILK AND VEGETABLES

Add the thin coconut milk and the boiled vegetables along with their cooking liquid. Simmer gently for 8–10 minutes, letting the flavors meld.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Stew, continued

05 ADD THICK COCONUT MILK

Reduce heat to low and stir in the thick coconut milk, along with black pepper and salt. Simmer very gently for 3–4 minutes — do not let it boil hard, which can cause the coconut milk to separate.

Texture indicator. the finished stew should be a pale, creamy broth, thick enough to coat a spoon lightly, with visible cracked black pepper throughout.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling the stew hard after adding the thick coconut milk is the most common mistake, causing the milk to split or turn grainy. Keep the heat low and gentle from this point onward.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served with appam (lacy, bowl-shaped fermented rice pancakes), the classic Kerala Christmas and Easter breakfast pairing.
- Also enjoyed with idiyappam or plain rice.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl alongside a stack of appam, garnished with a few whole curry leaves.

Family Style

- A gentle, aromatic dish that works well for a mixed table of spice tolerances, including children.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Aroma Right

- Blooming whole spices gently in coconut oil, rather than using ground spices, is essential to this dish's distinctive character.
- Freshly cracked black pepper, rather than pre-ground, makes a noticeable difference in aroma and warmth.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The vegetables can be pre-boiled a day ahead, with the coconut milk stew assembled fresh for the best texture.
- This stew reheats reasonably well on low heat, though always avoid boiling it hard when reheating.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Kerala Christian households add small pieces of boiled egg or cooked chicken to a portion of the stew for a heartier, non-vegetarian version, without changing the core coconut-spice base.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

190 kcal	3 g	16 g	13 g	4 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Kerala Vegetable Stew	the classic vegetarian version featured here.
Egg Stew	a popular variation with boiled eggs added to the coconut broth.
Chicken Stew	a non-vegetarian version using the same coconut-spice base with chicken.

Why did my coconut milk split?

Almost always boiling too hard after adding the thick coconut milk. Keep the heat low and gentle from that point onward.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I use only canned coconut milk?

Yes — use the thick cream from the top of the can for "thick" coconut milk, and dilute the remainder with water for the "thin" version.

Is this dish very spicy?

No — it's mild and aromatic, relying on whole spices and black pepper for warmth rather than chili heat.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Appam	a lacy, bowl-shaped fermented rice pancake, the classic pairing for this stew.
Idiyappam	steamed rice noodle "string hoppers," another common pairing.
Thengai Paal	Tamil/Malayalam for coconut milk, the base of this dish.
Karimeen	a popular Kerala fish, sometimes referenced in non-vegetarian stew variations.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Vegetable Stew

15m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

VEGETABLES

Carrot	120 g
Potato	150 g
Green beans	100 g
Green peas	70 g
Water	240 ml

STEW

Coconut oil	30 ml
Cinnamon stick	1 inch
Cloves	4
Green cardamom	3
Bay leaf	1
Onion	100 g
Ginger	10 g
Green chili	2
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
Thin coconut milk	240 ml
Thick coconut milk	240 ml
Black pepper	3 g
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Boil the vegetables.** Combine the carrot, potato, beans, and peas with water in a pot.

02 **Bloom the whole spices.** In a separate wide pot, heat coconut oil and add cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, and bay leaf, letting them sizzle gently for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

03 **Sauté the onion and aromatics.** Add the sliced onion, ginger, green chili, and curry leaves, cooking until the onion turns soft and translucent, about 5–6 minutes.

04 **Add thin coconut milk and vegetables.** Add the thin coconut milk and the boiled vegetables along with their cooking liquid.

05 **Add thick coconut milk.** Reduce heat to low and stir in the thick coconut milk, along with black pepper and salt.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Carrot	120 g
☐ Green beans	100 g
☐ Coconut oil	30 ml
☐ Cloves	4
☐ Bay leaf	1
☐ Ginger	10 g
☐ Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
☐ Thick coconut milk	240 ml
☐ Salt	6 g
☐ Potato	150 g
☐ Green peas	70 g
☐ Cinnamon stick	1 inch
☐ Green cardamom	3
☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Green chili	2
☐ Thin coconut milk	240 ml
☐ Black pepper	3 g

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